



"South India Tour – 14 Nights"

Meal Plan – Half board basis

Day 01	Arrive Bangalore By International flight
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Arrive Bangalore International airport in the evening hrs

Legend goes that King Veeraballa of Vijayanagara once lost his way in forest. Hungry and tired, he came upon a lone hut in the thick forest where he met an old woman. When he asked for food, she gave him baked beans ('Benda Kalu' in Karnataka). The King found this humble meal taste better than the richest fare. To commemorate this incident, he called the place "Benda Kalu Ooru"(place of baked beans). Bangalore today is getting popular though for a different variety of Beans-JavaBeans.

Capital of the Southern State of Karnataka, Bangalore today is Asia's fastest growing cosmopolitan city. It is home to some of the most high tech industries in India. The I.T industry views Bangalore as the 'Byte-Basket' of India

Meet - Greet & welcome by our representative, and transfer to hotel

On arrival, Check In at hotel

Overnight at hotel

Day 02	Drive to Hassan Surface – 190 Kms 04 hrs drive
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Breakfast at hotel
Check Out & drive to Hassan

Enroute city orientation tour of Bangalore by driving past Vidhan Sabha & other government buildings, Lal Bagh & Bull temple

Upon arrival, check in at hotel

Afternoon visit of Belur & Halebid

Belur & Halebid: This quaint hamlet –BELUR - 38 kms from Hassan - is located on the banks of the river Yagachi. It was once capital of the Hoysala Empire today made unforgettable for its exquisite temples. The Shennakeshava is one of the finest examples of Hoysala architecture. It took 103 years to complete this architectural marvel. The facade of the temple is filled with intricate and frescos, with no portion left blank. Elephants, episodes from the epics, sensuous dancers. They are all there - awe-inspiring in their intricate workmanship. Hand-lathe-turned filigreed pillars support the temple. The Veeranarayana Temple and the smaller shrines are worth a visit.



Halebid - Halebid is 27 kms northwest of Hassan and 17 kms east of Belur. The temples of Halebid - like those of Belur - bear mute testimony to the rich, cultural heritage of Karnataka. The Hoysaleswara Temple, dating back to the 11th century, is astounding for its wealth of sculpture details. The walls of the temple are covered with an endless variety of Gods.

Return to hotel by evening

Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel

Day 03

**Hassan / Mysore
Surface- 120 Kms**

Breakfast at hotel

Check-out from hotel and drive by surface to Mysore & visit of Sravanbelgola En-route

Sravanabelagola: is an important and one of the oldest Jain pilgrimage spots in India, 125 km from Bangalore. Nestled between Indragiri and Chandragiri hills, the city dates back to the 3rd century B.C. when Chandragupta Maurya wandered to the place in search of serenity and peace after handing over his empire to his son Bimbisara. The chief attraction of this sacred city is the 17m tall monolithic statue of Lord Gomateshwara, also known as Bahubali, which is said to be one of the tallest and most elegant statues of the world. Made by Chamundaraya, minister of the King Rachamatta of Ganga dynasty in 983 AD, it has been carved out a single boulder. The statue has found its place in the famous Manjunath Temple of Dharmasthala and symbolizes renunciation and self-control.



Further drive to Mysore

MYSORE - Or Mahishur as it was called then, traces its history back to the mythical past, when Goddess Chamundeshwari of Chamundi Hills killed the wicked buffalo-headed demon, Mahishasura. Mysore Dussehra is the celebration of this victory of good over evil. Mysore also has associations with the Mahabharata and King Ashoka of the 3rd century B.C. Mysore was the capital of the **Wodeyar** dynasty, feudatories of the Vijayanagar Empire, who declared their independence in the 16th century and ruled in Mysore until independence, barring three decades when Haider Ali and his son Tipu Sultan wrested power from them. Mysore today, is a pleasant city with an old world charm, contributed by its broad shady avenues, well laid out gardens, fine buildings and a salubrious climate

On arrival, check in at hotel

Afternoon city tour of Mysore

Mysore Palace (Ambavilas Palace): is a palace situated in the city of Mysore, southern India. It was the official residence of the former royal family of Mysore, and also housed the durbar (ceremonial meeting hall of the royal court). The architectural style of the palace is commonly described as Indo-Saracenic, and blends together Hindu, Muslim, Rajput, and Gothic styles of architecture. It is a three-storied stone structure, with marble domes and a 145 ft five-storied tower. The palace is surrounded by a large garden. The three storied stone building of fine gray granite with deep pink marble domes was designed by Henry Irwin. The facade has seven expansive arches and two smaller ones flanking the central arch, which is supported by tall pillars. Every autumn, the Palace is the venue for the famous Mysore Dashara festival, during which leading artists perform on a stage set up in the palace grounds. On the tenth day of the festival Vijaya Dashami, a parade with caparisoned elephants and other floats originate from the palace grounds. Dashara is the most extravagant festival of Mysore. The Dashara festival is celebrated in the months of September and October of each year.



The **Chamundi Hills** are located in India, close to the palace city of Mysore. Its average elevation is 1,000 meters. Legend has it that the demon Mahishasura, the king of the area that is currently Mysore, was killed by the Goddess Chamundeshwari (also Chamundi) after a fierce battle. The hills hence got their name and a temple of the goddess was built on the top. The goddess is also known as Mahishasura Mardini meaning she who slew Mahishasura. The temple has a very beautiful idol of the goddess wearing a garland of skulls. The temple has always been patronized by the rulers of Mysore. In earlier days, the Maharajas of Mysore would ride the ceremonial Dashara elephant during the annual Dashara festival, but after India gained independence, the idol of Goddess Chamundi is taken on an elephant.

Also visit colorful Devraja (Fruit) market

For a visitor to this city, Devaraja market is an apt place to get a flavor of the local people's daily life. With more than 100 years of history, this market is well knitted into the heritage of Mysore. If you are new to the bazaars of India in general, do not miss Devaraja Market. This is a good sample of a traditional Indian market place that are colorful, noisy, vibrant and a tad chaotic.



Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel

Day 04

In Mysore

Breakfast at the hotel

Visit of Somnathpur: 35 Kms west of Mysore these excursions are amongst the finest temples built under the Hoysala dynasty dating to the same time as the gothic cathedrals of the west.

In the afternoon visit Sri Rangapatnam

Srirangpatanam: is about 12 km from Mysore. Famous as the Tipu Sultan's former capital, Srirangpatanam is a picturesque island in the Cauvery River. The biggest of the three islands in the River Cauvery, it is about 5 km long and 2km wide. If you are searching for a scenic and quiet spot, this island can be delightful for you.

Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel

Day 05

Mysore / Ooty Surface- 168 kms 05 hrs drive

Breakfast at hotel

Check-out & drive by surface to Ooty

On arrival check-in at hotel

Afternoon enjoy toy train Suggest timings (Depart Ooty at 1400 hrs / Arrive Coonoor at 1505 hrs) Schedule is subject to change

After train ride visit to botanical garden

Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel

Day 06**Ooty / Cochin
Surface- 260 Kms 07 hrs drive**

Breakfast at hotel

Check Out from hotel & drive to Cochin Enroute lunch at local restaurant

On arrival check-in in to hotel

Late afternoon Witness Kathakali dance show in a Theatre

Kathakali classical dance of Kerala owes its transnational fame to the nearly 300-year-old. Kathakali literally means story-play and is an elaborate dance depicting the victory of truth over falsehood. Themes revolve around the two great epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. A Striking feature of Kathakali is the use of elaborate make-up and colorful costumes. This is to emphasize that the characters are super beings from another world. The spectators can feel his invisible presence when the heroine or her maid details dreams and ambitions through circular movements, delicate footsteps and subtle expressions. Through slow and medium tempos, the dancer is able to find adequate space for improvisations and suggestive bhavas or emotions. Costume is designed with lots of paint applied on the face of the artist. The pomp and magnificence of Kathakali is partly due to its decor, part of which include the 'Kireetam' or huge head gear, the 'Kanchukam' or the oversized jacket, and the long skirt worn over a thick padding of cushions

**Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel****Day 07****In Cochin****Breakfast at hotel**

Morning proceed for city tour of Cochin especially Fort Cochin area which is believed to be the oldest European settlement in India

Visit the Chinese fishing nets; *one of the fascinating attractions of Kerala. Their beauty is attributed to their size, elegant construction and the way they work. The Chinese fishing nets are popularly known as Cheenavala in Kerala, & St. Francis Church;* *the first European Church to be built in India. The history of this Church reflects the colonial struggle of European powers in India, from the 15th to 20th Centuries*

Further visit to the satellite towns of Kochi (Cochin) - Comprises visits to the Jew town & Synagogue **(Closed on every Friday & Saturday)**, Dutch Palace **(Closed on every Friday)** Portuguese Architecture and British Influences, all blending harmoniously with the basic Kerala heritage testify that the rulers of Cochin traded goods as well as knowledge with the visitors from far off lands.

Also enjoy a walk around Ernakulum, the new & modern part of Cochin
Evening at leisure

Dinner & Overnight stay at hotel

Day 08	Drive Cochin -Alleppey 60 minute drive
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Breakfast at hotel

Check Out from hotel & transfer to Alleppey

On arrival, Embark into House Boat

Long Ago there were wooden barges in the Back Water area to convey Rice Coir and Coconut from one village to another. The rice boat takes you through the Back Waters where you can walk through the water logged villages and experience the breath taking beauty.



Hot Lunch on board.

Sail through the Backwaters and enjoy rural Kerala life.

At Sun-set, drop anchor on the banks of the lake.

Dinner & Overnight on board

Day 09	Drive Alleppey-Periyar 160 kms/4 hrs drive
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Breakfast at hotel

Check Out & drive to Periyar

On arrival, visit the spice plantation in Thekkady is one of the major spice plantations in Kerala & captivating farms to wander in, since different spices are cultivated in different sections of each plantation. Accompanied by an expert naturalist, wander through systematically organized sections where exotic spices such as cardamom, black pepper, cinnamon, nutmeg, vanilla, and cloves are cultivated in their natural habitat. Along the way, discover the rich agricultural history, traditional harvesting techniques, and therapeutic uses of these spices, while enjoying the refreshing, spice-scented mountain air.

Further check in at hotel

Afternoon boat ride by boat on Lake Periyar, which carry you through the jungle with the possibility of sighting of elephant, bison, deer and occasionally, tiger. Small animals include black Nilgiri langur; bonnet and lion tailed macaque, Giant and Flying squirrel. There are some 246 species of birds and 112 species of butterfly. There are trees more than 100 years old and over 50 m high.



In the evening witness a performance of Kalaripayatu – the Martial Arts of Kerala

Dinner & Overnight stay at hotel

Day 10	Periyar / Madurai Surface- 170 Kms 04 hrs drive
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Breakfast at the hotel

Check-out from hotel and drive by surface to Madurai.
En-route visit of Rope making, Small School etc...

Madurai - The cultural capital of Tamilnadu. Here, the Dravidian culture reached its zenith in art, architecture, palaces and temple buildings. Once the capital of powerful Nayaka kings, a bustling city packed with pilgrims, businessmen, bullock carts and legions of rickshaw pullers. Its narrow overcrowded streets seem to be bursting at the seams with activity. Southern India's oldest center for pilgrimage and learning.

On arrival, Check in at hotel

Late evening witness Night ceremony at Meenakshi Temple_- Enjoy a short transfer by Tuk-Tuks

In the late evening, enjoy a short, spirited ride through the bustling streets of Madurai aboard traditional auto-rickshaws (Tuk-Tuk) to reach the magnificent Madurai Meenakshi Sundareswarar Temple. Here, you will witness the enchanting Palliyarai Pooja—the grand night ceremony that marks the end of the temple day. Accompanied by the resonant strains of the nadaswaram pipe, the thunder of temple drums, and Vedic chanting, priests carry the bronze image of Lord Sundareswarar (Shiva) in a ornate silver palanquin to the bedchamber of Goddess Meenakshi. Surrounded by the scent of camphor, jasmine, and incense smoke beneath towering, illuminated Gopuram, this mesmerizing spectacle offers an unforgettable glimpse into South India's living temple traditions.

Dinner & Overnight stay at hotel

Day 11**In Madurai****Breakfast at hotel****Visit to Flower market in the early morning**

At dawn, head out for a vibrant early morning walk through the bustling local flower market to watch the city gradually come to life. As the first light filters through the stalls, witness local vendors artfully weaving fragrant garlands of fresh marigolds, jasmine, and roses amid a lively kaleidoscope of colors and activity. Observe the energetic morning routine of local traders and early-bird shoppers before pausing to savor a piping-hot cup of traditional chai served in a classic clay cup (kulhad), offering a quiet moment to soak in the authentic morning atmosphere before returning to your hotel for breakfast

Breakfast at hotel

Later proceed for city tour to Madurai - Visit the *Thirumalai Nayak Palace*, a palace in Indo-Saracenic style built in 1636, with huge domes and 240 columns rising to 12 m, a beautiful garden and a attached museum. The celestial Pavilion, an arcaded octagonal structure is curiously constructed in brick and mortar without any supporting rafters.

Also visit Meenakshi Temple, an outstanding example of the Dravidian temple architecture from the Vijaynagar kingdom. Meenakshi, the fish eyed goddess and the consort of Shiva has a temple to the south and Sundareswarar (Shiva) a temple to the west. One of the biggest temples of India. Its nine "Gopuram"-Temple towers (23-30m) have wonderful stucco images of gods, goddesses and animals from the Hindu mythology.



And also visit Gandhi Museum

Rest of day at leisure

Dinner & Overnight at hotel**Day 12****Madurai- Trichy -Tanjore
Surface- 190 Kms/04 hrs drive**

Breakfast at the hotel

Check-out from hotel & drive by surface to Tanjore

En-route visit famous Srirangam Temple at Trichy

The temple occupies an area of 156 acres (6,31,000 m²) with a perimeter of 1,116m (10,710 feet) making it the largest temple in India and one of the largest religious complexes in the world. In fact, Srirangam temple can be easily termed as the largest functioning Hindu temple in the world being the largest non-functioning temple). The temple is enclosed by 7 concentric walls with a total length of 32,592 feet or over six miles. These walls are enclosed by 21 Gopurams (Towers). Among the marvels of the temple is a "hall of 1000 pillars" (actually 953).



Followed by Rock Temple Visit

Thereafter, depart to Tanjore (50 Km / 01 Hrs from Tanjore)

Tanjore, or Thanjavur as it was earlier called, was the capital of the Chola Empire from the 10th century to the 14th century A.D. later is become part of the Vijaynagar kingdom, then passed into the hands of the Marathas and later still went to the British. For ages it has been the chief political, literary and religious centre of the South. The celebrated temple Brihadeshwara built by the Chola King during the 11th century is its major attraction.

On arrival check-in at hotel

Late afternoon visit Brihadishwara Temple This is also called the big temple and it is dedicated to Lord Shiva. The great Chola king Raja Raja I (985-1012 A.D) built this temple. It is an outstanding example of the Chola architecture. Its unique architectural excellence has made the UNESCO to declare it a World Heritage Monument. The 64.8mts.Tall **vimanam** or the tower over the **sanctum sanctorum** is a testimony to the engineering skill of the Cholas. In keeping the immensity of the temple the gigantic **mahalingam** in the shrine measures 4 Mtrs. in height.

The monolithic Nandi or the bull mount of Lord Shiva has been chiselled out of single rock. It is the second largest Nandi in India. The beautiful Chola Fresco paintings on the inner walls of the temple are no way less than Ajanta paintings.

Dinner & Overnight at hotel

Day 13

Tanjore / Pondicherry
Surface- 190 Kms 04 hrs drive

Breakfast at the hotel

Check out from hotel & drive to Tanjore

En-route visit Chidambaram

Chidambaram is also known as *Thillai*, since the place was originally a forest of the *thillai*, botanically known as *excecaria agallecha* shrubs. It is an important pilgrim centre and a holy place for Saivites as the famous Nataraja Temple is located here. Dedicated **to Lord Nataraja**, this ancient temple of the Cholas is unique not only it is devoted solely to the art of Bharatanatyam, but also it is one of the rare temples where Shiva is represented by an idol rather than the customary lingam. Spread over an area of 40 acres with a gopuram on each side, the temple is distinguished by five sabhas or courts.

Later drive to Pondicherry

Pondicherry – a quaint enclave in Tamil Nadu Upholds the French tradition to this day. The town which rose phoenix – like, after the British literally razed it to the ground in the 18th century, is home to the much acclaimed Aurobindo Ashram and is noted for its lovely French architecture and cuisine.

Upon arrival check in at the hotel

Afternoon visit Aurobindo Ashram which was, founded by Sri Aurobindo a onetime Bengal evolutionary who later took to the spiritual path & Auroville, the city of Dawn was started in Feb. 1968 as a unique experiment in international living, where people live and work in total harmony. **Sri Aurobindo**



Ashram: The Sri Aurobindo Ashram located on rue de la Marine, is one of the most well-known and wealthiest ashrams in India, with devotees from India and all over the world flocking to it for spiritual salvation. Its spiritual tenets represent a synthesis of yoga and modern science. (*Children below 3 years of age are not allowed into the ashram*)

Dinner & Overnight stay at the hotel

Day 14	Pondicherry / Chennai Via Mahabalipuram
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Breakfast at the hotel

Check Out from hotel and drive to Chennai

Enroute visiting Mahabalipuram

Mahabalipuram: An Ancient Coastal Port South of Madras, here you will see many sculptures and temples of typical South India architectural design.

Visit the magnificent rock temples and carvings in Mahabalipuram. **Five Rathas (chariots) ceremonial chariots**, rock-cut monoliths, named after the 5 Pandavas - heroes of the Mahabharata epic and Draupadi their wife. **The Shore Temple** by the sea surrounded by gardens designed according to descriptions of the original layout from ancient times. Built in sandstone in the 7th century. Bhagiratha's Penance is a bas-relief (27 to 9m) sculptured on the face of two enormous adjacent rocks, depicts, the penance of Arjuna, myriad characters from the Mahabharata (a Hindu epic) with realistic life-size figures of animals, gods and saints depicting the descent of the river goddess Ganga to earth

Thereafter, drive to Chennai

Chennai - The city of Chennai or Madras as it was known earlier, traces its origin to 1639 when Francis Day a trader with the British East India Company, built a trading post – Fort St. George, near the village of Madraspatnam. Today Chennai is the fourth largest city of India with a population of 5, 5 million people. Also called as "Hollywood of India" it is the centre for making South Indian films

Check in at hotel

Dinner & Overnight at the hotel

Day 15**In Chennai**

Breakfast at the hotel

Depart for an excursion to Kanchipuram - the 'Golden City' which was once the capital of the Pallavas and the Cholas. These two powerful ruling dynasties gave the city its numerous temples and tanks. The city is also famous for its Kanchipuram Silk'. It has still has 150 active temples, dedicated various gods and goddesses. Kanchipuram is also one of 7 holy cities in India. In Kanchipuram visit the **Kailashnath Temple**, one of the oldest temples, built in the 7th century AD. It is built of sand stone and houses some of the most elegant sculptures of Natraja (Shiva in cosmic dance).



Later visit **Ekambareshwara-Temple**, the biggest in the city, are large complexes with mandapas, tanks and sculptured halls with devotees who still flock here. It has an ancient mango tree, and it's believed that its branches represent the four Vedas and its fruits are said to have a different taste. **(Non- Hindus are not allowed inside the main sanctum).**

Drive back to Chennai – Upon arrival, city tour of chennai - Take you to the 16th century Portuguese old Cathedral of St. Thomas Church in which the remnants of St. Thomas is buried who came to India in 52 AD. Pass by the University built in Indo-Sarscenic style, as well as 5 km long Marina Beach, a lovely esplanade by the sea.

Later transfer to hotel where room will be given till departure

Dinner at hotel

Later in evening, transfer to chennai airport to connect flight for onward destination

Day 16**Fly Out from Chennai
by morning flight**

Board to flight in time with sweet memories of India Trip

END OF THE TOUR

Check In time at 1400 hrs & Check Out time is 1200 hrs at all hotels